MODULE 4 · BUILD LIKE A FOUNDER

Go-to-Market *Strategy*

From zero to a sales pipeline.

TWO SESSIONS

Session 1

FRAMEWORKS YOU'LL MASTER

Positioning · Motion · Beachhead
Channels · Funnel · Moats · Team

Strategy | B2B & B2C

GTM is not about channels. It fails for ***positioning*** - and the discipline of putting signal ahead of spend.

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SESSION 1 OF 2

Positioning, motion & the *first 100*.

Build the strategic spine of your GTM - what to say, who to say it to, how to acquire your first 100 customers without burning the runway.

WHAT YOU'LL DO

- Positioning
- Motion & ICP
- First 100 B2B + B2C

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FRAMEWORK 1

The Positioning Brief - *four questions* that start every GTM.

Q1 · Who is it for?

A specific person in a specific trigger situation

Not a market segment. A role + a moment. "The VP of Ops at a 200-person SaaS who just hired their third SDR and realised their CRM is broken." That level of specificity.

Q2 · What job does it do?

The job-to-be-done, not the category

What outcome are they hiring your product to deliver? What does success look like? "Look competent to my board on pipeline" is a job; "CRM software" is a category.

Q3 · Why is it different?

Against the incumbent AND against "do nothing"

What can you say that competitors can't claim? One honest, measurable claim beats five vague ones. If a competitor can say it, rewrite it.

Q4 · Why now?

What changed in the world that makes this possible - and necessary

A technical, behavioural or economic shift made this real. Why couldn't this have worked 24 months ago - and what pressure drives the need today?

Single test: can you write *one sentence* your ideal buyer would repeat to their boss/friend? If not, the brief isn't sharp enough.

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TAKE-HOME TEMPLATE

Fill in the *six blanks*, defend in one breath.

THE SENTENCE - FILL IN THE UNDERLINES

For *[target buyer]* who *[trigger situation]*, *[company]* is the only *[category]* that *[unique capability]*, because *[Why Now]*.

- **Target buyer -** job title + role + the situation they're in
- **Trigger situation -** what changed about their job that opened the budget
- **Category -** what is the simplest name a market would search for?
- **Unique capability -** one claim a competitor literally cannot put on their site
- **Why-now proof -** a behaviour, capability, technology, or economic shift that makes timing sharp

4 HARD RULES

1. It must fit in one breath - under 25 words.
2. It must mention a specific person.
3. It must contain one measurable claim.
4. If a competitor could swap their name in, rewrite it.

"For Indian retail investors who refuse to be locked into a brokerage's research and order fees, Zerodha is the only discount broker that charges zero brokerage and zero account-opening fees - because flat-fee broking is finally legal under SEBI's discount-broker framework."

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Fill in the blanks

For Indian startups stuck in weeks-long bank integration cycles just to accept payments, <……> is the only payment gateway that gets you live in a single day - because RBI's payment aggregator licensing framework let non-bank fintechs own the full stack instead of reselling a bank's.

For first-time investors intimidated by broker paperwork and jargon, <……> is the only investing app that gets you from signup to your first mutual fund in under 10 minutes - because SEBI's Aadhaar-based e-KYC rules made fully paperless account opening legally possible.

For families in tier-2 towns with no specialist within 50km, <……> is the only platform that puts a certified doctor on a video call in under 15 minutes - because the National Medical Commission's 2020 telemedicine guidelines made remote prescriptions legally valid for the first time.

For small shopkeepers losing sales every time a customer didn't carry cash, <……> is the only payment app that turns any shop into a digital-payment counter with just a printed QR code - because NPCI's UPI rails made merchant onboarding free, instant, and hardware-free.

Fill in the blanks

For urban shoppers who need a missing ingredient before dinner's already ruined, <…..> is the only quick-commerce app that guarantees delivery in 10 minutes, every time - because it built its dark-store network from zero, purpose-designed for a 10-minute radius, instead of retrofitting an existing grocery business onto a faster delivery layer.

For households doing a full weekly grocery run without the time to juggle three different apps for produce, staples, and snacks, <…..> is the only quick-commerce app with big-store assortment delivered in minutes - because it inherited our supplier relationships and existing rider network, letting it stock deeper and deliver reliably from day one instead of building distribution from scratch.

For our already-habitual users who order food 3x a week and now also need a quick grocery run, <…..> is the only quick-commerce option that lives inside the app they already have open - because it inherited our existing riders, saved addresses, and payment details, letting it cross-sell groceries at close to zero net-new acquisition cost.

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Exercise – Lenskart

For _____ who _____, Lenskart is the _____ that _____ because _____.

Banned words

- innovative
- convenient
- seamless
- affordable
- premium
- customer-centric
- one-stop
- high-quality
- best
- leading

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Exercise – Lenskart

For young Indians who see eyewear as both a necessity and a fashion choice, Lenskart is the eyewear brand that makes stylish glasses accessible, affordable and easy to try - because its technology-led online model is combined with a large physical retail network.

TEST THE BRIEF BEFORE YOU COMMIT

Five cheap tests - each one runs in under a day.

01
Competitor test

Can a competitor literally say this - word for word? Send your statement to 3 competitor namesakes. If any would happily sign it, fail.

Cost: 2 hours. Pass when zero would sign it.

02
Specificity test

Does it name a measurable outcome - not a feature? Cut every adjective. Replace "fast, smart, easy" with the number you can defend.

Pass when one sentence has one number.

03
Timing test

Does it explain why now? Cite a behaviour, regulation, or technology that didn't exist two years ago - and would have made the product useless then.

Pass when the year matters, not just the buyer.

04
Repeat-to-boss test

Could your buyer quote it back to their boss in their own words? Run two 15-min calls. If they can't paraphrase it, the statement isn't sharp enough.

Pass when the buyer paraphrases it without prompting.

05
Reply-rate test

Encode the statement as a cold outreach headline. Send 50. If reply < 8%, the positioning isn't pulling weight.

Pass when reply > 8% on 50 sends.

THE DISCIPLINE

Most teams stop after Test 1 and call it done. Run all five before a positioning "decision" is announced. *A positioning that fails any one of these fails all of them - the first test that breaks is the most important one.*

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TWO INSIGHTS THAT WILL SAVE YOU MONTHS

Two things *most early-stage teams get wrong*.

INSIGHT 1

Don't position against the competitor.

Position against the current behaviour they live with.

Naming a competitor anchors your evaluation to their narrative - and tells the buyer to compare you on their axes, not yours. Position against the spreadsheet, the WhatsApp group, the manual process. Anyone with the problem now sits in your frame.

✗ **"We're 50% cheaper than Salesforce"**
Anchors to Salesforce's pricing, not your value.

✓ **"Close 30% more deals without a CRM learning curve"**
Outcome-led, never mentions a competitor.

INSIGHT 2

Free is not a strategy

Free without a pay trigger is cost, not strategy.

PLG works when the product is genuinely viral, delivers value before payment, and has one reachable moment where paying unlocks something. Free used as a discount by customers who'd have paid anyway is a margin leak.

✗ **"Free for up to 10 users"**
Cost without a moment to convert.

✓ **"Free until 10K messages, then $8 / user"**
Slack-moulded: paywall appears at the value ceiling.

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FRAMEWORK 2

Choose your primary *GTM motion*.

01 · Sales-Led Growth - SLG

Humans drive acquisition, expansion, renewal.

Buy when deal size justifies the conversation (typical ACV > $10K), when buyers are committees, or product requires configuration. Metrics: CAC payback, sales cycle length, win rate.

Best for: High-value deals B2B

02 · Product-Led Growth - PLG

The product drives acquisition and conversion.

Works when value lands within minutes and virality is natural. Metrics: time-to-value, activation rate, viral coefficient, free→paid conversion.

Best for: Self-serve products B2

03 · Marketing-Led Growth - MLG

Brand + content drive inbound trust.

Works when buying is considered, comparison-heavy, or trust must precede conversation. Metrics - content engagement, brand lift.

Best for: Trust-building B2B

04 · Community-Led Growth - CLG

Peers drive word-of-mouth.

Works when buyers benefit from connecting with each other and share a professional identity. Metrics: engagement, referral rate, NPS-augmented retention.

Best for: Network effects B2B/B2C

Most companies run more than one. **Pick one primary.** Add a second only after the primary produces predictable pipeline.

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WORKED EXAMPLES

The four motions

MOTION	COMPANY	PRIMARY ENGINE	THE MECHANIC
SLG	**Browserstack**	Sales	Salesperson navigates complex enterprise purchase
PLG	**Postman**	Product	Product usage brings more users
MLG	**CRED**	Marketing	Brand/content creates demand
CLG	**Zerodha**	Community	Users educate, help and attract other users
HYBRID	**Calendly · Notion**	Product followed by sales	PLG gets the team. Sales activates when usage, seats, or governance cross a threshold.

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Exercise – Canva

Canva - a simple online design tool that lets anyone create presentations, social-media posts, posters, videos and other visual content.

“You have to get 1,000 new paying customers. You can use only ONE growth motion. Design how you would do it.”

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Exercise – Canva

PLG:

"Try Canva."

The product demonstrates its value almost immediately.

SLG:

"Canva for your whole organisation."

A salesperson can sell collaboration, brand management, security, admin controls, etc.

MLG:

"Here's how to make a great Instagram post / presentation / resume."

The content itself attracts people who then discover the product.

CLG:

"Here's a template I made."

Users create things that attract other users.

Canva has three unusually favourable characteristics:

1. **Very fast time-to-value** - you can create something useful within minutes.
2. **The output is inherently shareable** - designs travel outside the product.
3. **Large potential user base with relatively low individual ACV** - making self-serve acquisition economically plausible.

A 5-STEP DECISION FLOW

From inputs to *a single motion* in five questions.

Step 1	Step 2	Step 3	Step 4	Step 5
ASP - what's the product cost?	Buyer - individual or committee?	TTV - time to first value?	Complexity - config or self-serve?	Buyers talk?

ENDS IN SLG

High-ASP, complex deals

- ACV ≥ $10K, often > $50K
- Multi-stakeholder buying
- Long TTV, configuration
- Founder-led sales to start

ENDS IN MLG

Considered, trust-first

- Mid-market ACV ($5–50K)
- Buyers research before buying
- Comparison shopping is normal
- Trust must precede price

ENDS IN PLG

Self-serve, fast TTV

- ACV < $5K (often < $1K)
- Individual buyer
- TTV minutes, not hours
- A reachable pay trigger exists

ENDS IN CLG

Professional peers already gather

- Buyers are also practitioners
- Peer conversation changes adoption
- A community already exists
- Net Promoter carries referral weight

Anti-pattern: running all 4 motions before PMF burns focus and runway. Pick one end - run it for 4–6 weeks - measure conversion - then revisit.

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DECISION RULES

Motion picker - *lead with one*, add a second only after.

LEAD WITH ONE MOTION FIRST

Focus → Predictable pipeline

Pick one primary motion

Start with the strongest fit. Add secondary only after generating pipeline.

STATUS
Primary

Prove before expanding

Get 10+ paying customers from one before adding others. Validate first.

TRIGGER
10+ wins

Time-box the experiment

Run the primary motion for 4–6 weeks before deciding to add a second.

WINDOW
4–6 wks

Validate before scaling

Pipeline must be consistent before layering complexity.

THRESHOLD
Repeatable

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FRAMEWORK 3

Beachhead - three stages, *in sequence*.

1 STAGE 1

Beachhead

Own a segment where you can win decisively.

· They have the problem acutely

· Reachable through existing channels

· Win produces a credible story for the next segment

Today

Dominate before expanding.

2 STAGE 2

Adjacent markets

Same underlying problem, slightly different context.

· Use case studies from beachhead

· Reuse proven messaging

· Reduce trust barriers with social proof

Next

Reuse proof for expansion.

3 STAGE 3

Broad market

Scale channels into a broader market.

· Repeatable acquisition is in place

· At least one adjacent converted

· Proven conversion rates & CAC

Then

Scale with proven proof.

THE 80/20 OF BEACHHEADS

A beachhead that owns **80% of a $5M** segment is worth more than **2% of a $200M** market.

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SCORE YOUR BEACHHEADS

5 criteria · score 1–5 · the higher, the better.

CRITERION	WEIGHT	SCORE	TOTAL
Pain intensity How acutely they have the problem today.	×3	4	12
Reachable in 60 days You can find 50 of them.	×3	5	15
Win produces a story Reference-able for the next segment.	×2	3	6
Short feedback cycle You learn weekly, not quarterly.	×1	4	4
Money on the table Real ACV - they can pay.	×2	5	10
Total weighted score Run this on two segments.			**47 / 55**

WORKED - INDIAN D2C OPS TOOL

Beachhead: 30–80-person D2C skincare brands running Meta ads at ₹3L+/mo.

- Pain: 4/5 - CSVs and GST-ready reports are a daily headache
- Reachable: 5/5 - 50 names on LinkedIn in a week
- Story: 3/5 - adjacent segment sees the same pain
- Cycle: 4/5 - weekly usage data
- Money: 5/5 - $15–50K ACV realistic

DECISION

Lost to thin-types of "wellness brands" because the story lacks teeth. Pick "skincare-first" - the story sharpens.

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FRAMEWORK 4A

First 100 customers, *B2B* - four stages.

Stage 1

TARGET
10 customers

Your network

1–10 customers · signal over revenue

· Identify from the warm network - design partner swap

· Reduced price in exchange for structured feedback

· Goal is signal, not revenue

· After every purchase, ask: "What made you decide to buy now?"

Stage 2

TARGET
30 customers

Cold expansion

11–30 customers · cold + community

· Build list with LinkedIn / Apollo / Clay against your ICP

· 20–30 personalised cold messages per week

· Show up in 1–2 communities where ICP gathers

· Ask every Stage-1 customer for one introduction

Stage 3

TARGET
60 customers

Referral engine

31–60 customers · content + ask

· Ask at peak satisfaction, with a clear next step

· Publish content that answers ICP questions

· Track source of every new conversation

· Goal: inbound interest from expertise

Stage 4

TARGET
100 customers

First paid tests

61–100 customers · spend only after CAC is set

· Test one paid channel with small budget ($500–$1,000)

· Define target CAC before spending

· Build a case study from the first 30

· Map highest-LTV acquisition source

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CARRY-FORWARD · WORKED TABLE

First 100 B2B - *what each stage actually looks like*.

STAGE	INPUTS	MECHANIC	PASS CRITERIA
1 · Your Network **1–10 customers**	Warm network, prior employer, ex-colleagues, design partners signed in 1:1 conversations.	Reduced price + feedback loop. Founder hand-sells. Recorded calls.	10 customers who can describe the trigger moment and the outcome.
2 · Cold expansion **11–30 customers**	Outbound list built against ICP. 1–2 community channels where the buyer gathers.	20–30 personalized messages per week. Reply rate › 8%. Warm intros from Stage 1.	At least 1 paying customer from cold outbound. Community is producing a weekly signal.
3 · Referral engine **31–60 customers**	Lessons from Stage 1 convert to content. Existing customers refer peers. Email list builds.	Structured referral ask at peak satisfaction. One new article / week. Source-of-conversation tagged.	≥ 25% of pipeline is inbound or referral. Two published pieces driving real conversations.
4 · First paid tests **61–100 customers**	Repeatable conversion above 12%. CAC target set. At least one case study.	Single paid channel, $500–$1K budget. Lead source tracked. Result documented weekly.	Paid CAC predictable within ±30% of target. Source of highest LTV is identified.

Sequencing rule of thumb: Each stage should take 6–10 weeks. Skip a stage only with evidence - not hope. Cooler-headed is faster.

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B2B PLAYBOOK

Cold outreach that *converts*, not just sends.

1 · List build, with triggers

Use Apollo / Clay / LinkedIn Sales Nav to build against your ICP.

200 prospects ≥ 5 triggers

Trigger = something that changed about the buyer's job recently. Hiring, regulation, growth, tool change.

2 · One true observation

Every message contains one observation that signals you've actually looked. Titles are not observations.

✗ "I see you're a VP of Sales"
✓ "I noticed you just hired 3 SDRs and posted for a RevOps lead."

3 · Three-part message

1 observation · 1 insight about the problem · 1 low-friction ask.

"I noticed [observation]. [Insight]. Open to a 15-min call to tell me if I'm solving the right problem?"

4 · 4–5 touches, 14 days

Each touch adds new value - never "just following up."

Day 1	Day 3	Day 7	Day 14

If 5 touches get no response - move on. Brand damage compounds.

32% target	12%+ target	5–8 cadence	40–60%
Open rate	Reply rate	Meet / week	Meet → Opp

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FRAMEWORK 4B

First 100 customers, *B2C* - four stages.

Patience over spend. Fix retention before you acquire.

Stage 1

TARGET
500–1,000

Pre-launch · waitlist

Build anticipation, qualify interest

- Landing page with sharp value proposition
- Seed in 2–3 communities with credibility
- Engage every signup at least once
- Genuine intent, not numbers for the sake of numbers

Stage 2

TARGET
D1 › 20%

Aha in the first session

Drive D1 retention up

- Release to waitlist in batches, not all at once
- Track D1 / D7 retention obsessively
- Watch where users drop in the first session
- Push every session toward the aha moment

Stage 3

TARGET
K ≥ 0.5

Organic loops

Refer at peak satisfaction

- Build referral into the product, not bolted on
- Trigger at peak satisfaction, not the dock
- Reward with status, not just discount
- Track invites × conversion rate weekly

Stage 4

TARGET
100+ customers

Paid, with proof

Spend only after D30 › 20%

- Seed 20–30 micro-influencers (5K–50K followers)
- Early access for authentic content
- Paid only after D30 retention passes 20%
- Reward word-of-mouth before impressions

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CARRY-FORWARD · WORKED TABLE

From waitlist to fit - *what each stage looks like*.

STAGE	MECHANIC	TRUTH TO CHASE	PASS CRITERIA
1 · Waitlist **Pre-launch · 2–4 wks**	Sharp landing page, manual signups, community seeding, 1:1 conversations.	The waitlist earns the launch. Quality counts more than the count.	500–1,000 signups with at least 25% identifiable in your ICP.
2 · Aha session **Launch week 1–2**	Batch release, instrumented onboarding, D1 retention tracked daily.	The product either earns the second session or doesn't.	D1 retention › 20%, an aha moment documented with one observable cue.
3 · Loops & invites **Week 3 onward**	Built-in referral trigger, social currency rewarded, frictionless invite.	Sharing must feel natural. Status › discount.	K-factor trends up; D7 retention stable or improving.
4 · Micro-influencer **Month 2–3**	Seed 20–30 micro-creators, pay for results, hold organic as the backbone.	Authentic creators first; impressions come second.	D30 › 20%. ≥ 3–5% conversion on seeded creator posts.

Discipline: Spend comes last. Two of the cautionary cases on slide 6 burned because they bought acquisition before retention.

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WORKED MATH

K-factor - and the *D30 gate*.

K-FACTOR MATH

K = invites per user × invite conversion

INVITES / USER	CONVERSION
2.5	20%
Target › 3 invites within 14 days.	Target › 25% via 1-click invite.

Result · K = 0.50 · PMF-light territory

THE D30 LADDER

Don't spend a rupee until retention clears a gate.

BUILD	SCALE	COMPETE
≥ 25%	≥ 35%	≥ 45%
D30 minimum	First paid tests	Heavy spend

A leaky bucket isn't a fast bucket - it just empties faster. Retain before acquiring.

WORKED - IMPROVING K OVER 3 WEEKS

Week 1	Week 2	Week 3
1.6 × 15%	2.2 × 18%	2.8 × 22%
K = 0.24	K = 0.40	K = 0.62

What changed

Trigger time moved from session 1 to the moment of aha. Invite copy went from "Tell a friend" to "Show your team the dashboard view." Conversion lifted twice - invites lifted once.

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END OF SESSION 1

What you should now *be able to do*.

01
Diagnose why GTM fails.

Watch attention-vs-retention metrics. Most failure is retention, not acquisition.

02
Write a Positioning Brief.

Six prompts, five tests. Know who you're not for before who you are.

03
Pick a motion deliberately.

Sales-led, PLG, community, hybrid or brand-led - and why yours, this market, now.

04
Score a beachhead you can defend.

Five criteria, three segments. If the winner is < 9, abandon and pivot.

05
Plan your first 100 customers.

B2B or B2C. Three different problems: reach, win, retain.

06
Hold the line on a D30 gate.

Don't pay for acquisition before retention clears the floor; K math before scale.

✗ Don't ship a vague positioning

✗ Don't optimise only acquisition

✗ Don't scale before D30 holds

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SESSION 2 OF 2

Channels, growth & the *next hundred*.

Six channels that actually scale, three growth systems you can ship under uncertainty, and the team & measurements that turn GTM from art into a number.

WHAT YOU'LL DO

- Channels
- Growth systems
- Funnel & metrics
- Team, scale, moats

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